

**THE
UNITY
OF THE CHURCH
ESSENTIAL
TO THE
CONVERSION
OF THE
WORLD**

by

**James Henry Gwyther
M.A.**

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THE CHURCH ESSENTIAL TO THE CONVERSION OF THE WORLD

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THE UNITY OF THE CHURCH ESSENTIAL TO THE CONVERSION OF THE WORLD.

A SERMON,
PREACHED BEFORE
THE DIRECTORS AND FRIENDS OF THE LONDON
MISSIONARY SOCIETY,
DURING
Their Anniversary
IN MAY, 1846,
IN THE CHURCH OF ST. MARY, SPITAL SQUARE,
LONDON,

BY
J. H. GWYTHER, M.A.
VICAR OF MADELEY, SALOP.

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SERMON.

“Neither pray I for these alone, but for all who shall believe in me through their Word: that they all may be one: that the World may believe that thou hast sent me.”—JOHN xvii. 20, 21.

The last earthly act of one we love and honour, is often referred to with deepest interest, and revolved with the most thoughtful attention. It is then that the dying Parent delivers his solemn counsels, and unbosoms his most sacredly cherished feelings. If ever the tenderest and earnest workings of the heart are laid open, it is as the scene draws near and yet nearer to its close.

And as our beloved SAVIOUR approached the termination of His earthly history, the strong commanding feelings of his soul were displayed, and then especially he taught his disciples what sentiments he would have them cultivate, and what objects he would have them propose; whilst by his example, he taught them in *what spirit*, and by *what means* to seek those high and holy ends.

It was then, assembled with his disciples in the Garden of Gethsemane, that He as the Great High Priest of Our Profession, breathed forth in earnest prayer, the words before us:—

“The last acts of the Great Mediator, were acts of prayer.”

HE prayed! that he might impress his people with the importance of prayer. He made them *witnesses* of his prayer, that when they hereafter might follow him their divine intercessor, *by faith*, within the veil, they might know for what ends, and in what spirit, his intercession is carried on. His LAST ACTS *were prayer*. It was in *prayer* that he closed his last interview with his Apostles. It was in this exercise that he passed his hour of agony in

the Garden; and when on the Cross, His dying breath was spent in repeated and solemn application.

Oh! beloved brethren! 'twas a solemn scene;—the adorable Mediator with the shadows of death deepening around him, employed in earnest addresses to his FATHER. The Garden—the Judgment Seat—the Scourge—the Cross, were full before him. On what now is His spirit bent? On what subjects does he meditate? His prayer will tell, and tell how fully his heart was occupied with the work of mercy—the well-being of his church—the honour of his Father—the salvation of the world. It was then he uttered the prayer in which he sought for his people, that they all may be one, that the world may be converted to him. He had *charged* them “to love one another.” He had shown them that they were *virtually* “all one:” By the sacred supper, he had sought to cherish their love and union, and now by his example he taught them to make it the burden of their prayer. And even still his heart longs for this! He looks down from his exalted throne, upon that church which he so much regards, and which he “has purchased with his own blood;” that church to which he has entrusted such a high and glorious work; big with the richest blessings for a ruined and wretched world. He sees that church divided, torn, distracted, alienations and strifes prevailing, whilst the world’s millions are waiting, *uninstructed, unenlightened, unblest*; and then, having connected the conversion of the world with the unity of the church, he again pours forth the intercession, “Father, may they all be one, that the world may believe that thou hast sent me.”

In the endeavour to fulfil that duty, which the Directors of the London Missionary Society have assigned me, I feel I need your sympathy, and your prayers. I stand before you “in weakness, and in fear, and in much trembling.” From a sense of my own insufficiency to perform this duty aright, as well as from the conviction that I may be standing in the room of some more qualified and acceptable advocate of the cause, I was naturally reluctant to leave the quietude of a country village and place myself in this public situation: on the other hand, believing that this was a call from God, to bear my humble testimony to His truth in this great Metropolis, and that in endeavouring to do his will, we shall not fail of his grace; I have come beloved brethren, and would seek to offer a few remarks upon the interesting subject now introduced to your notice. The subject I am fully

aware, is now one of those to which so much attention has been given of late years, that I cannot hope to present it more clearly or forcibly than it has already been placed in your view: all I can attempt is to bring these things again to your remembrance, and again to urge them upon the attentive consideration of the Christian Church.

In doing so, I propose to consider three things—

- I. The object, which in this Petition, the SAVIOUR seeks.
- II. The means by which it is to be promoted.
- III. The reasons why it should be most earnestly desired.

We must proceed to notice:—

I.—*The object, which in this petition the Saviour seeks.*

It is the unity of all *believers* upon Earth. Not indeed that CHRIST is indifferent to the peace and love which ought to bind together *all mankind* as one great family. He purposes to secure *this*; but he seeks to bless His Church, that thro' it he may bless the world. Yes! beloved brethren,—Men ought to “*be one*” in the bonds of love and kindness. We are Brethren, all “one man’s sons,” and where there is a man, there is one who has a claim upon the thoughtfulness, the care, the kindness of his fellow man; and in order to promote the general well-being of our species, we should be *as one*. To us there cry the poor in their destitution—the ignorant in their darkness—the oppressed in their wrongs—the victims of war, murderous and impious war—the slaves in the chains, which tyranny has thrown around their persons, or set on their intellect and conscience; *these*, and sufferers in every other form of woe, appeal to *man*, the *family*, the *fraternity* of man, for sympathy, pity, and relief. They are Men; they are Brethren; and these are outrages against our common claims, which should rouse all that hear the cry, to succour the suppliants. We have all one FATHER, and happy will be the time, when His divided and distracted household, shall again “love as brethren;” when the oppressor shall cease; when “violence shall not be heard in our borders;” when the clangor of war shall give place to the melting sounds and celestial song of “Peace on earth, and good will towards men;” when truth shall fill all intellects, and love reign in every heart. Bright! Glorious Day!—And shall this happy

consummation ever bless this afflicted, burdened, groaning world? It shall! The Gospel *purposes it*, and to secure its accomplishment, the Gospel is daily putting forth its heavenly energy, and ere long, earth in love shall be the very emblem of the heaven of heavens. The fierce passions of the human spirit shall be subdued. “The wolf also shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the kid”; “the cow and bear shall feed”: “they shall not hurt nor destroy in all my holy mountain; for the earth shall be full of the knowledge of the LORD, as the waters cover the sea.”—ISAIAH xi, 6–9.

But another work must precede this. The Church must first be *made one itself*. The universal harmony predicted, and eventually to be realized in the world, must first pervade the elements of CHRIST’S Visible Church, and therefore as a means to that great end, even that the world may believe in, fully recognize, and submit to the authority of Him, whom GOD has sent, the Redeemer here prays, that His disciples may “be one;” implying thereby that the unity of the Church, is the great pre-requisite for the conversion of the world.

1.—*And who are His Church, His People, the subjects of this prayer?*

None but those who rest upon His atonement, and rely upon His grace, as the one foundation of their hope for eternity. It is not the bearing of a Christian name; it is not an enrolment in any society, however scriptural in doctrine and apostolic in discipline that constitutes men Christians. There may be loud profession—an orthodox creed—ceaseless activity—large sacrifices, without *faith* in JESUS or *love* to his name. But *these* are indispensable; without *them* there is no interest or fellowship with CHRIST, and no part, or lot in His Church. Without *faith*, there is no salvation; and “if any man love not our LORD JESUS CHRIST he must be accursed.” The possessors of these alone, are the true “living stones built up a spiritual house.”

But the Church includes *all who believe on the Son of God*, among whatever community they may be found. Each christian may *have*, and ought to hold *dear*, his convictions, as to the truths the bible teaches, and the church principles which are there developed.

The Bible is ever to be his standard, and his conscience binds him to receive *all* that it teaches. We plead for no latitudinarian indifference. We have *our* convictions, nor dare we yield them, unless GOD should, by His Spirit, afford us another view of truth; nor will any candid christian, who differs from us, call for such a sacrifice. We ask not for such unwarranted concessions from any. Nor dare we judge the LORD's servants; to their own Master they stand or fall. To Him they are amenable, and it cheers the spirit to think that our minor errors and imperfections hinder not Him from receiving any who rest on Him for mercy, and yield to Him their hearts.

All these are His people—they are parts of His universal Church; though severed from each other, they are one with Him; members of His mystical body; branches in Him the Living Vine!

And where shall we seek them? They are found adorning fellowships of varied names, and each possessing features of peculiar beauty, and sacred excellence. We dare not say that a connexion with any system of itself can make men Christians; nor of Episcopacy, Presbyterianism, Congregationalism, nor Methodism, that it is exclusively THE CHURCH OF GOD, so as to monopolize all sacred relations and existing piety. But we believe that genuine disciples of CHRIST are to be found amongst them all.

The churches which have numbered among them a Fletcher, a Henry Martyn, a Cary, a Williams, a Wesley; will furnish their portion towards the one great assembly, “the church of the first born written in heaven.”

The genuine disciples of the SAVIOUR, are to be found in various ranks, and among different denominations of Christians; from these many have been gathered already, and swell the throng around the throne of GOD above. Even now the multitude collected from among them, is greater than any man can number; they have lost their party badges and sectarian titles. This is their only distinction, “They have washed their robes, and made them white in the blood of the Lamb,”—and they need no other—this is their great *title*—this secures them a happy, blissful place before the throne of GOD and the Lamb; and they desire no more.

And many yet are found *below*. True our minds are distracted by the differing names and varied distinctions which exist among us. But be of good cheer, beloved brethren, upon a goodly company, though widely

scattered, CHRIST looks down with joy, seeing in each of the throng, a trophy of his love; a soul saved by his sacrifice, and transforming to his image.

The SAVIOUR's prayer contemplated *all these*, and sought that they may *all be one*. And indeed they so far are even now *one*.

There is a bond which binds them to each other, which no power can sever. It is that spiritual tie which unites them to CHRIST; in Him they are all one. They were ONE in *ruin*—in separation from GOD—in captivity to Satan—in exposure to eternal death. They now are partakers in a common salvation—redeemed by the same blood—renewed by the same Spirit—relying upon one Saviour—Children of one Parent, they form one holy family, and will spend an eternity together in their “Father's House.” Thus real, substantial, and indissoluble is their union. They are one, as CHRIST is in the FATHER and the FATHER in Him.

But, alas! this ill accords with the aspect they present to the world, and the attitude in which they stand to each other; nor can the prayer of CHRIST be silent, until the *one-ness* of his people shall be *felt*, and their union shall be manifest to all.

2.—Then we may further enquire—*Wherein must such union consist?* It is clear, not in the adoption of *one common name*; for such may be, and the aim be entirely lost, and the object of the SAVIOUR unattained. Something of this kind was realized in the dark ages. The Church of Rome then contained within itself well nigh all existing nominal Christianity. But did this, think you, brethren, realize the prayer of our LORD? *One* name embraced men of every varied creed, and covered every form of abomination. A one-ness, where except for the title “Christian,” and for the form of godliness, no religion seemed to exist; life and soul were lost, the frame-work alone remaining. This one-ness was that of the tenants of the sepulchre and the grave yard, where the fellowship was that of an universal corruption, and the calm was the stillness—the silence of death, only broken by here and there a mourner, weeping that the dry bones were so many, and that they were so very dry.

No, this is not the peace we long for, and for which CHRIST prays. Better, a thousand fold better, is our present state, than such an unity as that. It is at least replete with *life*, though disfigured by diversities. We have spirit, and

we have power; though that spirit is too frequently expended in strife, and that power in warfare.

The *first thing essential* to the attainment of Christian Unity is, that Christians should be brought to *feel* that real one-ness, which even now exists between them.

There is a principle which is inseparable from the existence of vital godliness, and that is faith in CHRIST. Now if all who look to the work of CHRIST for justification, and confide in the HOLY SPIRIT for sanctification, are really Christians, why should they not be felt to be such, and loved as brethren? CHRIST loves them,—let them love each other. To all of them JESUS is precious; then let our hearts embrace with ardour all “who love our LORD JESUS CHRIST, in sincerity;” and if we can do this, there will be but little difficulty in rendering that unity visible. How can it be concealed? For where there is true love, there must to some extent be friendly intercourse—sympathy will be engendered—in spite of existing distinctions, love will draw us together into kindly greetings, and social fellowship. Nor will there be wanting opportunities of co-operation in efforts to diffuse the Bible, extend the Gospel, and convert immortal souls.

And even where this may not be, there will be witnessed a cordial interest in each other’s labors of love; we shall rejoice when prosperity attends the work of others employed with us in the same holy enterprize, and mingle our tears with those which disappointments cause to flow from the eyes of our beloved and devoted brethren; and only let this but be realized, and all bitterness, and envy, and malice, will speedily disappear. If Christians differ in opinion, yet they will agree in heart; if they are constrained to exhibit their views strongly, they will aim to do so with “the meekness of wisdom,” and with the kindness of charity.

Oh, for this consummation! Believers, labour and pray for it—sacrifice for its attainment your party jealousies—mortify carnal prejudices, and crucify the spirit of bigotry; and thus hasten the accomplishment of the SAVIOUR’S prayer, when we shall all be one—one in love—one in our great aim for reviving the church, and saving the world—one in fervent prayer—and shall all value, more than any other title, the *one* new name given to the disciples at Antioch.

Having considered somewhat at length *the object which in this petition of the SAVIOUR, he more especially seeks*; namely, the unity of his Disciples; a one-ness in his Church; let us in the second place, advert to *the means by which it is to be promoted*.

And here I need scarcely remark, that *coercion* can do nothing: neither ecclesiastical canons, nor authoritative edicts, can sway the conscience, or influence the affections. Nor can even much reliance be placed on moral suasion, or controversial discussion. We may acknowledge the importance of the object, but be after all undecided as to the method of its attainment, or indifferent to its ultimate success. The great means are with God; yet all of us can do something towards the promotion of Christian Union, and I would humbly suggest the following hints:—

1.—*By personally cherishing, and prominently keeping in view those great truths upon which the Church of Christ has agreed.*

For after all, to use the admirable language of a Christian author upon this subject; “The unity which the Church of CHRIST should maintain within, and promote without, even in our present circumstances exists, and that substantially, though imperfectly. Its existence is proved by an identity of motives and aims; proved by that similarity of sentiment, which makes the Christian find a new brother in every converted man; proved by petitions and praises, like in matter and in manner, and offered to the same throne of grace; proved by the general correspondence of our forms of worship. Were some enlightened heathen, such as Cicero, to rise up and come among us, he would perceive little difference among the purest Christians, unless his attention were called to it by some formal partisan. The grand and glorious features of the Christian faith, would stand out before him in bright contrast with those of heathenism, if our paltry animosities did not obscure them.”

Let us then set before us, and steadfastly gaze upon the great soul-elevating, and spirit-uniting doctrines of the Gospel. The atonement of CHRIST—His perfect work—finished redemption—spotless righteousness—all prevailing intercession, and final conquest. The work of the Spirit in the regeneration, sanctification, and perfection of believers. These are the great master-truths; let them be to our souls, what they are to the Gospel, the Alpha and Omega, the foundation of all; and much will be done in enlarging our

views, refining our judgments, breaking down prejudice within, and concentrating our affections upon points of general agreement. In addition to this, let the mind of CHRIST be ours. His mind was absorbed with love to his FATHER, and compassion for souls. Cherish the same; let this predominant passion occupy and control our spirits, and there will then be but little space found, and less taste felt for those trifles which distract, divide, and embitter.

2.—We may promote this Christian Unity further, *by seeking to form, and convey a right impression of our own excellence, in comparison with the worth of others “who follow not with us.”*

We are too prone to dwell with much of sectarian gratulation, upon the peculiar advantages of *our own* communion, or the evidences of divine favour we have been blessed with; to the disparagement of others, from whom we differ. That spirit, whilst it leads us to vain boasting, as infallibly leads to a despising of our brethren. Rather let us mourn over our own imperfections and short-comings; let us recall to mind how feeble and often futile have been our efforts; how our piety has mingled with much of *earthliness*, our love with much of *selfishness*, our zeal with much of *partiality*, and our devotedness with much of *self exaltation*.

On the other hand, let us be willing not only to allow, but even to rejoice in the excellencies of others—to ponder their worth and their works—to cast the sin-covering mantle of true christian charity over the infirmities of our brethren, and to rejoice with them in their success, weep with them in their discouragements, and aid them in their necessity. Thus we shall, as saith St. Paul, “look not every man on his own things, but every man also on the things of others.” Each preferring his brother in honour and in love. The bonds of christian union will be strengthened, and the dove-like spirit of peace condescend to dwell in the hearts of christians, constraining even the world, as of old, to confess—“see how these disciples love one another.”

3.—*Christian Unity is to be promoted by co-operation in those wise schemes of christian effort, which may consistently embrace all who love the Saviour.*

Co-operation has ever been found very powerful in producing and sustaining unity. In such christian efforts, there is a common object

proposed; a measure of agreement in the means to be employed, in order to its attainment; a participation in responsibility; a sympathy in trials; an interest in success; all which bind kindred hearts; unite in holy brotherhood those who share in the same common-wealth and privilege; and allay those feelings of envy and jealousy which have so fearfully agitated and divided the body of CHRIST.

Thanks be to GOD, we live in an age, when such efforts are put forth, in which we may conscientiously co-operate with our brethren, in the great and glorious designs they contemplate. By so doing, we shall help much to complete the unity of the Church.

Yet, beloved brethren, why enumerate more means? There is one influence, which adequately employed, would secure the whole. What want we, but a large and universal effusion of the Holy Spirit? Oh, yes! this would do it all.

It would fix our gaze upon ourselves, until we sank abased in the dust. It would attract us all to the cross; that whilst drawn to one common centre, all would be drawn closer to each other. Such would appear the transcendent glories of that object, that all others would in comparison lose their power to charm or interest us. The ruin, guilt, danger, wants, and woes of a perishing world, would awaken our tenderest compassion and ever watchful solicitude.

Eternity unveiled—heaven in its peerless glories—hell in its hopeless torment, would so bring our spirits under the “powers of the world to come;” that we should be blind, and deaf to all things of inferior moment. Were this gracious influence but felt and cherished, all would indeed be one. Divisions would be healed. Stumbling blocks be removed. Hearts joined to hearts. Joys mingled with joys; and the blessed SAVIOUR’S prayer, receive its full accomplishment, and His people be one, even as He and the FATHER are one.

It remains for me in the Third place, to direct your attention *to the reasons, why this Christian Unity should be so earnestly desired.*

Now here we might, if it were necessary, advert to many and weighty reasons, for seeking to promote and increase this spirit in the church of

CHRIST. I shall only however, fix upon the two more immediately connected with the text; the one *implied*, and the other *expressed* by it. The first is derived from *its being the great prevailing desire of our divine Redeemer*. It rested much upon His heart, or he would not have prayed so earnestly for it. He was then going forth to gird himself for His arduous undertaking. He was about to engage in fierce conflict with the powers of darkness. He had before him the accomplishment of a glorious work—the vindication of the divine honor—the illustration of the divine perfections!—the recovery of a ruined and apostate race—the establishment of a kingdom, which eventually should be co-extensive with the world. In doing all this, he would have to pass through scenes of humiliation, suffering, and death. He would have to assert his victory over death and the grave, by raising himself, and “spoiling principalities and powers, make a shew of them openly, triumphing over them.” He would finally have to ascend up on high, “leading captivity captive,” to receive his reward, and claim his kingdom; to mark the success of his cause, and the triumphs of his cross. But he plainly foresaw how intimately that success, and these triumphs, were connected with the unity of his disciples—how preeminently their one-ness constituted their strength—of what vast importance to his ultimate conquest of the world, was the mutual agreement and brotherly love, which His people should evince. And so he interceded, with a spirit yearning for the fulfilment, and deeply interested in the result, “FATHER I pray that they all may be one.”

And if this desire be so strong on the part of the Redeemer; if this unity be dear to him, should we not, His professing followers, esteem it as worthy of our regard? Yea! as of the first moment? Can we feel indifferent, when the honor of GOD, and the glory of JESUS are involved? Can we be *unconcerned* spectators of the present divided and discordant spirit which prevails among us?

Nay, surely christians, your master longs for unity. Lay aside every other consideration, and let his will be paramount, and your desire and prayer be “that they all may be one.”

The other reason I would adduce for the cultivation of this spirit, arises from the direct *influence such unity is to have upon the conversion of the*

world, (as stated in my text,) “I pray that they may all be one, (in order,) that (as a means to an end,) the world may believe that thou hast sent me.”

The conclusion then, at which I would desire to arrive, is, that such unity is essential to the final triumph of the Gospel; that if we desire the latter we must seek to promote the former; and in fact, that unless we are willing to strive for—sacrifice for—pray for the spirit of unity; our efforts, zeal, and devotedness will be virtually defeated.

And now look, beloved brethren, what is the state of the world in this the nineteenth century? Eighteen hundred years have rolled away, since the command was given by the Great head of the church, the risen and ascending SAVIOUR, “go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.” And still the Prince of darkness maintains his sway among the nations. Idolatry and superstition, the chief pillars of his throne, are resting in almost every land. Darkness still covers the earth, and gross darkness, the people. Out of 900 millions of immortal souls, scarcely 300 millions are even nominally Christians. To multitudes the name of JESUS is a sound unknown; and the glad tidings of His grace and salvation strange things.

My brethren, ought these things so to be? Or would these things have so been, if the church of CHRIST had risen to her duty; in a word, had greater union prevailed among her members? She has had strength, resources, opportunities; she has not lacked zeal, intelligence, nor encouragement; but she has expended her strength, in that which profiteth nothing; her resources, in fostering intestine warfare; and perverted her opportunities, to promote sectarian dogmas, and anti-christian strife. We are called bitterly to mourn these departures from the Spirit of CHRIST; and thus with shame, to confess that we are verily guilty concerning our heathen brethren. Upon the christian church, has been laid the obligation to preach to them the Gospel; but alas! we have fearfully neglected our duty, or at least very inadequately performed it.

But see, my beloved brethren, what influence this christian unity would exert, and what consequences would follow from it in the conversion of the world. *For the church would then be a witness for the truths and excellence of the glorious gospel*—and how important is that! It is in *the church* that the men of the world study the gospel. They care not to investigate its real

nature, as revealed in the bible—they care not to study its features, in the character of CHRIST—they care not to attend to its delineation in the ordinance of preaching. But they *can* see it in professors—and they will scrutinize their character, and keen sighted and vigilant are they in detecting evil, and discerning imperfections. And how invariably have the division, discord, and strifes of the church, laid a stumbling block in the way of the enquirer—strengthened the worldly in their prejudices against the truth, and confirmed the unbeliever in his incredulity and contempt.

But on the other hand; a church, *spiritual, zealous, devoted, one in love to each other*, in love to CHRIST and love to souls, would bear upon itself its own credentials. The world convinced by such evidence, and impressed by such scenes, would acknowledge “that GOD was with us of a truth,” our religion would be honoured, and “the name of our LORD JESUS CHRIST glorified.”

And again—*if such unity existed and prevailed, the whole undivided energies and resources of the church, would be at liberty, and ready to be devoted to the extension of the gospel, and the salvation of the world.*

Much strength is now lost in our conflicts with each other—much squandered upon vain and profitless discussion. Let these hitherto mis-employed energies be called forth—these perverted resources gathered into the proper channels; and then may we not hope that the church of CHRIST would present an unbroken front to the powers of evil, and move on one compact and irresistible host to secure the happy subjection of all things to our Redeemer.

The cultivation of this spirit moreover, would place us in a state of eminent preparedness for our glorious work. Our minds would no longer be engaged in minor objects, but would constantly recognize the one great end—the conversion of the world to CHRIST. All occasions of envying, strife, and division being removed; what agents would Christians be in this holy enterprize? Men baptized with pity for souls and love to JESUS—burning with ardent zeal to make him known—counting not their lives dear unto themselves, so that they may set forth the unsearchable riches of CHRIST. And in answer to the united prayers of such an united people, CHRIST would send forth his Holy Spirit as it never yet has come.

Yes! beloved brethren! only let there be unity in the church, and scenes, of which Pentecost was but a type, an imperfect emblem, will presently appear. Much has been done in preparing for the approaching harvest. The seed is thickly sown, and is being sown still more thickly. The preached word—millions of bibles—the hundreds of millions of tracts—the labors of Sunday schools, and the efforts of missionaries; all these have scattered wide the sacred gospel.

And now what wait we for? Oh! beloved! for the shower which these united prayers of the united church shall bring down; then, and not till then, nations will be converted to JESUS; the world will be brought to his feet believing; earth shall raise its triumphant song—“Hallelujah for the LORD GOD omnipotent reigneth. The kingdoms of this world, &c. Hallelujah.”—The church *is one*.—The world is CHRIST’S.

Having already detained you so long, I feel reluctant to trespass upon your patience further. I must however not forget that my duty would be still more imperfectly performed than it has been already, were I not to make honourable mention of that great and noble society; the claims of which I would in conclusion urge upon you.

I say *great and noble society*, for such verily it is; whether you regard the broad and catholic principle upon which it was originally founded—the eminent and pious who have adorned its ranks—the devoted, self-denying, and exemplary men who have been its missionaries—or the signal success and peculiar blessing with which the “God of all grace” has crowned its operations.

These are days in which missionary societies proceed with rapid strides; and it is interesting to a devout and enlightened mind, to review the history of such institutions; to trace them in the infancy of their existence, the feebleness of their first efforts, the perils and danger attendant upon their course; and then to rejoice in every year of their advancing strength and prosperity.

In the case before us, whether we consider the signs of the times when the foundation of this society was laid, amidst the fall of thrones and the convulsion of the civilized world; or the limited means and feeble agency, with which it commenced its efforts for the redemption of the nations; or

the gigantic obstacles, both at home and abroad, which were then presented to its progress; or whether we glance at the superhuman and glorious results, which in every sphere of its labours have rewarded its toils; reason, no less than piety, will give utterance to humility and praise in the poetic strains of inspiration, “not unto us O LORD, not unto us; but to thy name give glory, for thy mercy, and for thy truth’s sake.”

We rejoice in the happy contrast presented to our view, between the state of things *now*, and that of *former days*.

When this society commenced its benevolent career, there were many formidable obstacles with which the originators of such institutions had to contend. Great ignorance and gross mis-conception prevailed as to the real condition, social and moral, of Pagan nations. The visitors of heathen countries had contented themselves with merely glancing at the surface of society, even often purposely refraining from a detail of evils and enormities they could not have failed to have observed, whilst others denied the vices they had no care to suppress, and the existence of miseries which their own interest or influence had served but to aggravate.

It was indeed maintained that the negro race in general, the Hottentot in particular, was the connecting link between the animal and human species, though partaking far more largely of the attributes of the brute, than the similitude of the man.

But on the other hand, the inhabitants of the east were glowingly described as blest with civilization, and enlightened by science; and although the objects and forms of their worship were diversified, yet as their eulogists affirmed, their veneration for their gods was sincere and unbounded; while in social life, they were patterns of excellence—kind in their tempers, and lovely in their manners—living to make each other happy, and dying in the assurance of paradise hereafter. Such were the popular falsehoods to be combated and refuted, at the very outset of the missionary enterprize.

But where are now the advocates of Paganism, and the apologists for Idolatry? The moral condition of the heathen is better understood to-day, by the children in our schools, than it was by the enlightened classes of society fifty years ago; and the necessity of the gospel to meet the wants, and heal the sufferings of mankind, has become a familiar and undisputed

truth. And by whom have these idle tales and gross fabrications been exposed? By the men of GOD, sent forth from our midst, who have lived *with* the heathen, and *for* the heathen; from whose concurrent testimony the church has learned, and the world has been constrained to admit, that idolatry in all its varied forms, is an abominable thing; that its principles are founded on falsehood and absurdity, and that its requirements are cruel and obscene.

In the early days of missionary efforts, the fields of labour were necessarily few and contracted. The wide and effectual doors opened to us were then closed, and for admission our revered forerunners entreated and pleaded in vain.

Their ardent zeal panted for access to the teeming and degraded multitudes of India. But by the merchant, the soldier, and the statesman, the christian missionary was alike denounced and resisted. The robber and the spoiler were found in the train of the British conqueror; but the minister of heavenly mercy might not set his foot upon those distant shores.

Now, thanks be to GOD, how altered is the scene; the legislature of our country has awarded religious freedom to India; and now the missionary may go through the length and breadth of that mighty empire, testifying to the Mussulman and idolator “repentance towards GOD, and faith towards our LORD JESUS CHRIST,” unmolested by the natives, and befriended by his countrymen. If the early friends of missions excluded from the millions of India, turned their attention to the colonies of the west; there the curse of slavery rested with all its unmitigated horrors. And whilst christian compassion wept over the lacerated body, or the more tortured spirit of the deeply injured negro; the stern voice of the oppressor forbade the application of the balm that might have soothed and healed his bleeding heart. In the judgment of the slave-holder to instruct the negro in the mild principles of Christianity, was an offence not to be forgiven, an evil pregnant with every conceivable danger; and of all men, the missionary was the man most to be dreaded and detested. But the spirit of justice, philanthropy, and religion, maintained the hard fought contest, till the spirit of oppression though unchanged, was compelled to yield; and amidst the scenes where Smith was martyred as the friend of the slave—where the sanctuaries of GOD were pillaged and destroyed—where faithful brethren

were seized, imprisoned, and threatened with death, *there* liberty has been proclaimed to the captive, and *there* the glorious gospel of the blessed God has gladdened and governed the hearts of thousands. In Southern Africa also where the arms of our country had triumphed, British power was exerted for the support of slavery, and the discouragement of christian missions. The feelings of the colonists in general, were well expressed by the Dutch farmer, who in reply to the proposal of Robert Moffat to preach the gospel to his servants, exclaimed with a voice of thunder!—"preach to the Hottentots—preach to the dogs." But *now*, thanks be to the God of missions, the Hottentot is free; the Caffre is protected, and the wandering and hostile tribes of the desert enjoy the advantages of liberty, order, and peace; sanctified and enhanced by the blessings of religion.

But surpassing all other wonders of a gracious providence on behalf of missions—China, which from time immemorial barred her gates against the stranger; which ten years ago appeared equally impregnable for ages to come. *China itself is open!* Opened to an extent far beyond our power of occupation. Already the faithful evangelist proclaims the gospel of salvation in her crowded cities, none making him afraid, and many giving welcome to his message.

Of the christian missionary then, so lately proscribed in the east and west, excluded from the deserts of Africa and the cities of China, it may now be said "the world is all before him where to choose, and providence his guide." Can we not trace the hand of God in all this, and say "what hath God wrought."

To form a just estimate of the benefits that have directly resulted from the missionary labors of this and other kindred societies, during the brief period of their varied efforts, it is necessary that we should attentively consider the magnitude of our design—the conversion of 600 millions of idolators to christianity—a multitude diversified in habits, language, and character—the limited amount of agency that has yet been employed—the antiquity of the various systems of idolatry which prevail, in contrast with the novelty and strangeness of the gospel claims; and above all, the perfect congeniality of heathenism, to the depraved principles and passions of the human nature, in opposition to the humbling and sanctifying influence of Christianity. These considerations are suggested, not for the purpose of alleviating

disappointment and bespeaking forbearance to a narrative of failures; but rather to heighten our pleasure and enlarge our gratitude, that amidst obstacles so gigantic and with means so limited, we have in the short space of fifty years been favored through the divine blessing, with success so varied and abundant—success, both in character and amount, it may be confidently affirmed, greatly exceeding the largest expectations of the fathers of the cause.

This society has laboured to bless suffering man amidst the different forms of his guilt and misery, in Asia, Africa, Polynesia, and the West Indies. And in which of these wide fields of its mercy has it failed? It has laboured for his happiness in relation to the life that now is, as well as that which is to come, and in which of its designs of mercy has it not succeeded? Behold the triumphs of christian missions in the peaceful villages and cultivated plains of Africa—in the contentment and prosperity of the West Indian freed-man—in the Polynesian savage, transformed into the kind husband, the tender parent, and the happy man!

What numerous evils have not been terminated, and what daring crimes have not been prevented by the influence of missions? How many a widow, otherwise doomed to perish amidst the horrors of the burning pile, now lives! How many an infant, destined to die by the hands of its mother, is now pressed to her bosom! How many a victim, marked as a sacrifice to the gods of his country, now trusts and adores the GOD of salvation! Yes! we do rejoice in these supplementary advantages of christian missions; but had our success been limited to these, we should have deemed success itself a failure. Our first, our noblest aim, is not to civilize but to *evangelize* the heathen; not only to raise the savage to the dignity of man, but to raise man to fellowship with GOD.

And in every scene of conflict with error and sin, the champions of the truth have maintained a good fight, and have been heard exulting, “now thanks be to GOD who always causeth us to triumph in CHRIST, and maketh manifest the savour of his knowledge by us in every place.” Theirs is no empty boast, as they indulge these joyous strains. They point in *Africa* to the wandering marauder, once more ferocious than the lion which prowls amidst her sandy deserts, now harmless and gentle as the lamb! In *India* to the Brahmin, once the object of idolatry, now of scorn; once caressed by

friends and loved by kindred, now a solitary outcast; “but what things were gain to him, he has counted loss for CHRIST.”

In the *Isles of the Pacific* to the man, once both the destroyer and consumer of his fellow man; but now the cannibal delights in peace, and breathes the amenities of love.

In the *West Indies* to redeemed multitudes, once in harder and viler bondage than their crudest oppressors could impose on their emaciated frame; but the SON OF GOD has made them free, and “they are free indeed.”

But on the other hand this society has had to mingle her tears with her praises, and exhibits the trials as well as the triumphs of faith.

From Madagascar the shepherds have indeed been driven, and their flocks scattered; they wander amid the wilderness as lambs among wolves, and many have been offered as a sacrifice upon the altar of their faith.

From the deserts of Siberia also, where for more than twenty years our faithful brethren laboured with untiring zeal, to plant amid those snowy solitudes the garden of the LORD—they have been driven from their much loved toil.

In Tahiti also, where our fathers gathered their plenteous, yet long delayed first-fruits, we have been called to reap the bitterest sorrow. The envious eye and malignant spirit of popery could not tolerate that fair field of protestant faith and apostolic piety; and in the Government of France she found a mind sufficiently ungenerous, and a hand sufficiently oppressive, to effect the desolation of that lonely island. Alas! freedom bleeds, and injustice triumphs in Tahiti. The people have fled from their homes to breathe the air of freedom in the fastnesses of the mountains, and the christian queen is now a fugitive from her native isle.

Nor these things only. Our success has provoked the zeal of our adversaries. Idolatry, which once regarded our efforts with silent scorn, now feels our power, and arms itself for resistance. Popery tracks the footsteps of the christian mission; not in Tahiti only, but in China, India, Africa, the West Indies—on every soil they tread.

Yes! beloved brethren, we must not dream of repose, or allow our past success to lull us into security or indifference.

The hosts of earth and hell are opposed to us; they unite in strong phalanx against the LORD, and against His Anointed. *Unity* is their watch-word, for *unity* is their strength—combination and co-operation are their principles. Let us be taught by the enemy; let us put on the whole armour of GOD, that we may be able to stand in the evil day; and *over all*, “put on charity which is the very bond of perfection.”

Remember, beloved brethren, that in an united advance against the enemy, the victory is sure. The Captain of our Salvation is now gone forth conquering and to conquer. To Him are given “the heathen for his inheritance, and the uttermost parts of the earth for his possession.” And “He must reign until he shall have put all enemies under his feet.” The cause, the glorious cause is advancing! Christians will you not help it? The conflict has begun! Christians will you not join it? The final triumph of Messiah is at hand; even now the angelic hosts are preparing their golden harps to celebrate with the rejoicing heaven and redeemed earth, the consummation so ardently anticipated by the Redeemer—so long desired by the church—so cordially hailed in promise—so fervently supplicated in prayer; even the complete unity of the church, and by consequence

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